CYRUS FIELD (1819-92)

The businessman Cyrus Field, who had entered the paper business when he was 21, and who retired at 33 with a fortune, promoted the laying of the first transatlantic telegraph cable. He had no technical knowledge to qualify him for the task, but he was a brilliant and persuasive organizer. He also had a determination that helped him overcome repeated failures. The idea of laying a transatlantic cable was not new, but because of the great depths and distance involved, no one had promoted it. In 1854 a Canadian engineer interested Field in laying a cable from St. John's, Newfoundland, to the Canadian mainland. This would speed the receipt of European news by several days. While studying a globe, Field decided that the cable should be extended to Ireland. Laying the Canadian cable took two and a half years. By that time Field had organized companies in the United States and Great Britain to raise funds for an Atlantic cable between the two countries. The first four cables broke, causing heavy losses to investors. The fifth was completed on August 5, 1858. On August 15, Queen Victoria and President James Buchanan exchanged messages on the new cable. Soon, however, the signals became unintelligible, and in October they ceased. Undeterred, Field raised additional funds. After another failure in 1865, the fight was finally won on July 27, 1866.

EXERCISE 1: Find words or phrases in the passage which mean the same as:

	COLUMN A	COLUMN B
a)	encourage to exist	
b)	put (something) in a particular place or position	
c)	able to influence or convince people	
d)	the state of being very eager to accomplish something	
e)	defeat [verb]	
f)	an instance of being unsuccessful	
g)	the land area of a country without its islands	
h)	move along fast; make faster	
i)	obtaining something sent	
j)	an object like a ball, used as a model of the Earth	
k)	a sum of money raised for a cause	
l)	person who puts money into a business or businesses	
m)	give and receive	
n)	unable be understood	
o)	not discouraged	

EXERCISE 2: Choose the correct answer according to the passage.

1. According to the passage, Cyrus Field completed the laying of a transatlantic cable.....

A) sooner than was originally planned
B) with the support of Queen Victoria of the United Kingdom
C) with great perseverance and despite several setbacks
D) in a time of two and a half years
E) thanks to his vast technical knowledge of telecommunications

2. It is clear from the passage that, at the time he first came up with the idea for a transatlantic cable, Cyrus Field.....

A) had already completed a shorter cable in Canada
B) was just starting out in the paper business
C) was already a wealthy retired businessman
D) had studied telecommunications for several years
E) had met both Queen Victoria and President James Buchanan

3. It is mentioned in the passage that Cyrus Field was good at.....

A) organizing things
B) geography
C) fitting cables
D) deep-sea diving
E) journalism

EXERCISE 3: Complete the sentences by selecting words from Column B in EXERCISE 1.

1. I recorded the interview onto a cassette tape, but apparently, the tape was faulty as most of the recorded interview is.....
2. Several people laughed at his plans to open an outdoor heated swimming pool in England, but,.....he built it and opened it to the public last year.
3. The Channel Tunnel connects the island of Great Britain with the.....of Europe via a railway link.
4. Maps of the world give us a representation of our planet, but they give a somewhat distorted picture as the world is not flat. A/An....., however, gives us a far more real idea of how the different continents and oceans combine to make up the Earth.
5. He started his own computer company, but unfortunately, his venture ended in .....He now has a job with the Post Office and is content with working for someone else.